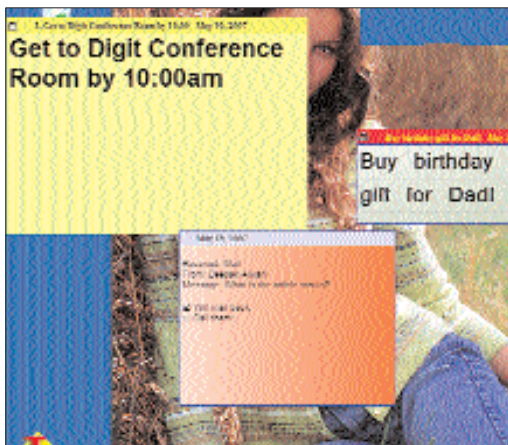




TurboNote lets you create post-it notes for your Desktop, but it goes way beyond just that much

Then, we've all had our moments when we've entered the same birthdays and anniversary dates in multiple calendars, or had to manually enter every number on the two phones you use regularly so their address books match. Here comes to our rescue the Synchronise function—a great way to save time. Use it liberally: sync your address books, e-mail clients, and sync your online calendars with Outlook (for example). If you use Firefox across multiple computers, use the Google Browser Sync extension to synchronise your browser settings like bookmarks, history, cookies, and saved passwords across your computers. Get it from www.google.com/tools/firefox/browsersync.

Methodologies

Speaking of GTD, propelling you towards getting more out of your time and not getting distracted is the Getting Things Done ideology, which was devised by David Allen, a productivity trainer and consultant. Allen devises a system of working for 10 minutes straight without any interruptions, and then rewarding yourself with a two-minute break at the end of it. Doing that five times straight will make for a very productive hour. Get yourself a timer software to clock yourself; we recommend MultiTrack Stopwatch 2.3 (<http://tinyurl.com/yud664>), a free, no-frills, Windows-based stop-watch. The idea here is not to complete every task in 10 minutes, but to make sure that you have made *some* progress in the 10 minutes. The drive that the reward causes can propel you to become more and more productive. Eventually, you'll actually *want* to work more and rest less...

At which time, you follow the 30-10 formula, wherein you work for 30 minutes straight after which you take a 10 minute break to do something you would normally do in your free time—like checking your RSS feeds or e-mail. Again, the idea here is to make progress on the goal at hand and not to try to necessarily complete the task in 30 minutes.

First-Hand Advice

Here are a few suggestions for office workers from Dr Rajendra Barve, President of the

With the (10+2)*5 formula, you'll eventually want to do more work

Bombay Psychiatric Society and a visiting faculty at IIT Bombay.

- ☑ Use artificial tears (saline water) for dry eyes. You could substitute saline water with cold water too.
- ☑ Take Vitamin A supplements, but consult your family doctor first.
- ☑ Another method recommended for tired eyes is “palming,” which involves rubbing the palms together to make them slightly warm, then, holding them as cups, place them over your eyelids for a while till you feel a sense of calm.

Dr Barve recommends creating the right ambience to work in. Listening to light music creates a barrier between you and your distractions. Another technique is to use the “accommodation reflex” technique, which requires you to focus on objects randomly that are far away for a minute. This enables the eye muscles to relax. (The glare on the screen could also be reduced by decreasing the brightness level of the monitor.) He goes on to say that when we have work to do, it is important to let people know that we must not be disturbed. Learning the art of saying “no” or “not now, later” is very important: it lets you focus on the job at hand. You could also give people “time-slots”, within which they're allowed to disturb you—no other time.

Opinions

We asked a couple of techies about their biggest distractions and how they worked around them.

Trupthi Indulkar, who works for Infosys, says, “Annoying ring tones are the bane of every workplace. Most people might not share your opinion of the ring tone being ‘cool.’ Educate people around you to keep their mobile phones on vibrator mode, and don't forget to follow the rule yourself! Also, if you are targeted by the telemarketers trying to sell you time-shares and bank loans, accept calls only from known numbers.”

Vikrant Agarwal, who works for Oracle, has this to say: “The biggest distraction is when I am in the middle of an important analysis and trying hard to concentrate, and then all of a sudden this group of caffeine addicts come along saying, ‘Let's go for coffee.’ They surround you and won't leave without you! Solution: take your coffee breaks when there is work to be done. This will ensure that you return to your desk sooner.”

In Parting

This writer has more important stuff on his hands than writing an unnecessarily long sign-off note, so here goes: your mileage with what we've advised will vary. Go ahead and devise your own methods of staying focused. But remember, always think of all the options you have in terms of what you can do next. It should then be obvious what your priorities are based on your circumstances, how much time you have, how much energy you have! ☑

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